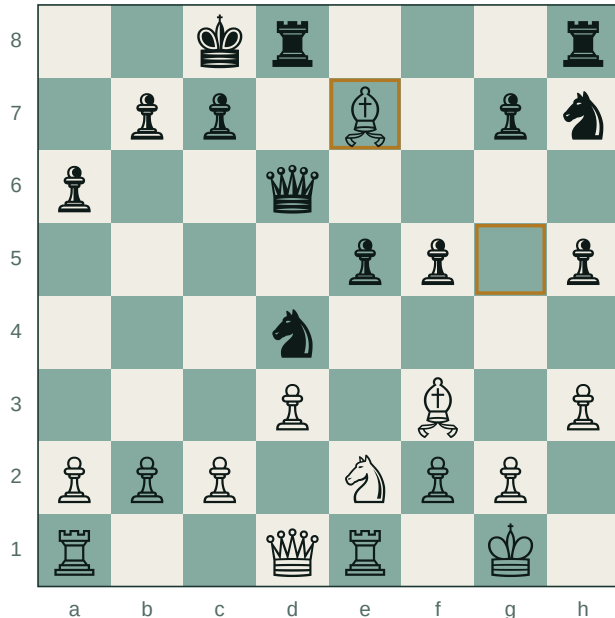


# Intermediate moves: Black, move 20

Intermediate moves

Black to move



Previous move: 20.Bxe7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**20...Nxf3+ 21. gxf3 Qxe7**

**20...Nxf3+** Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. From f3 it attacks king on g1 and rook on e1. Recorded reply: **21.gxf3**.

**21...Qxe7** The queen captures the bishop on e7.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

**CHECKPOINT**

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -3 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on e7. Check for tactical protection.